

30-35 per cent. This can't be done by the Central Government alone. Therefore, we need a partnership with all state governments to move forward together. It is time for us to evolve a national strategy.

Ideally, I would like chief ministers to have a national dialogue as to how we are going to increase the gross enrolment ratio at the school level. For that, we have now, through the Right to Education Act, made education free and compulsory. It is free for the children and the governments must provide education compulsorily to them. This effort will take about Rs

2,00,000 crore. We, along with the state governments, will be able to manage about Rs 1,40,000 crore but we will still be short by Rs 60,000 crore. So we have to sit together—the Central and the state governments—to figure out as to how that finance will materialise. We must be able to deliver quality education to our children so that when they move into the university system, there is a critical mass of high quality students, who can actually contribute to university life and move on to research and create intellectual property. For this to happen, we need a uniform national curriculum framework on the basis of which various state governments are going to base their syllabi. The national curriculum framework is an intrinsic part of the Right to Education Act itself and we have an academic authority which will be set up for it.

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Nearly 80 per cent of India's population resides in villages and rural children are not in a position to bear the fee of private schools. If we look at these 80 per cent people, we will understand the ground realities of basic education, intermediate as well as higher education. Uttarakhand is a new and mountainous state with difficult geographical situations because of remote villages. Children have to walk about 3 km to reach their school. High schools and intermediate schools are about 10 km from their homes. Another challenging issue is the quality of education. The world is changing, new innovations are taking place but have we equipped our teachers? If we are unable to equip teachers how will we equip our students?

Then we will have to reform the entire higher education set-up. But reforming the higher education system means freeing the universities from the control of the Government and making sure that the Vice-Chancellors are appointed not through a political process, but through a process of collegiums—manned by highly reputed academicians who have nothing to do with politics. You have a university system which decides as to what their courses should be, what kind of multi-disciplinary training should there be and what kind of universities should we have. Each university must be unique in itself, must offer something different and must embrace excellence. In order to do this and to reform the higher education sector as well as the school education system, we need to expand the system. We need to make education inclusionary. But we must not compromise on the quality and standards. The mantra for moving forward in the education sector is expansion, inclusion and excellence. If you have expansion without excellence, you will not reach anywhere. If you have expansion without inclusion, you won't be able to take the society along with you and if you have inclusion without excellence then those who are included will always be left behind.

We can't do it alone. The government does not have the wherewithal to carry the entire burden of education on its shoulders. This is not just a partnership between the Central and the state governments; it is a partnership between the civil society, the NGOs, parents, students, teachers. If it is a true partnership, then only will it move forward. And we would like the pri-



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